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Bush was as irrational as mythifying Obama as the Last Man of Deliverance.

The period of transition was a revelation: Obama refused to entrap himself in the loftiness of change. He was wise enough to acknowledge an old truth: the struggle against power is a romance, but managing power is not. Take his appointments. They are a clear indication of continuity and pragmatism. Guantanamo will be closed and "extraordinary rendition" will be stopped but Obama is too smart a politician to shock America as a spread-the-wealth, humour-the-Ahmadinejads radical from the Left. As unifier and reconciler, he cannot afford to be an ideological zealot; he will have to be a centrist. The presidency is not a continuation of the campaign; and his first address to the nation has spelt out his primary agenda—the restoration of the

American economy. There is a dash of communitarian idealism when he talks about the age of responsibility. Still, home may be the first priority of every president, especially for the one who has the missionary zeal of an FDR, the charm of a JFK, the eloquence of a Reagan and the intelligence of a Clinton; but the world beyond will test his leadership.

It is a world without justice, and where ancient hatreds are still in combat, as in the Middle East. It is a world where the war against

civilisation is waged in the name of God, Mumbai being its latest site. "We will not apologize for our way of life, nor will we waver in its defence", said the president, "and for those who seek to advance their aims by inducing terror and slaughtering innocents, we say to you now that our spirit is stronger and cannot be broken. You cannot outlast us, and we will defeat you." Isn't it what Bush has been practicing all these years, first in Afghanistan and then in Iraq? He has, understandably, left out Pakistan, the most secure factory of jihad. It is also America's indispensable ally in the war on terror. Will Obama live up to his own words? "If we have actionable intelligence about high value terrorist targets and President Musharraf will not act, we will," he said in 2007. Post-Musharraf Pakistan has not ceased to be the global capital of Islamist terror, but America refuses to abandon its selective post-9/11 morality in which certain varieties of evil are still use-

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ful. Obama is perhaps the most popular politician on this planet—a global brand of transformative power. For someone who owes his glory to a large extent to what he considers his predecessor's flawed response to 9/11, there should not be much difficulty in identifying the root of that flaw. Will Islamabad then replace Baghdad as the new site of American heroism? That is one question President Obama cannot evade. The answer will determine if he is the change we can believe in. ■